

The Wager: A Tale of Shipwreck, Mutiny and Murder
by David Grann

I can't wait to review this book. Found it on the bookshelf my wife and I use for future reads. She picked it up some time ago but hadn't yet read it. Historical nonfiction at its best. Published in 2023. I'd never heard of the Wager (a British man-of-war boat) that ran aground near an island off Patagonia in the mid 1700s.

A very useful and often consulted series of maps of the routes taken by the boats in a squadron under the leadership of a British commander named Anson got a yellow sticky early on when I read this book. (This helped me turn to the maps.) The period covered by the author is roughly 1742 to 1746. Anson left Portsmouth with his man-of-war and six others. One of them was the Wager. A fellow name Cheap was its captain. The objective was to sail all the way to the tip of South America and then head north across the Pacific. They were looking to find Spanish ships, attack them, and haul all the gold, silver etc. back to Great Britain.

Imperialism was sectioning off the globe during this time. What is now the United States was English colonies and French possessions. South America was half Portuguese, half Spanish.

The dangers caused by violent seas, terrible weather and enemy boats are graphically portrayed by Grann. Starvation, sickness, and infighting ultimately took the lives of many who took the trip. When the Wager ran aground the other men-of-war continued north. Finding food, building shelter, building makeshift boats consumed the castaways.

When one of the men is shot by Captain Cheap things begin to unravel and ultimately the men split up into two factions. One heads northwest on the Pacific to try and meet Anson, the other heads northeast on the Atlantic to head back to England.

Many onboard kept extensive journals. Bulkley, the gunner, wrote daily. He lead the group that finally made it to Buenos Ares. His record in particular serves as a key resource for the author. Miraculously, Cheap and two others make it back to England. Bulkley and his very diminished crew did too. There is a court-marshal trial. Mutiny is punishable by death. (Spoiler: no one loses his life). At the beginning of the book the author encourages the reader to decide for themselves based on the evidence.

This very little known story has finally come to light due to the brilliant work of David Grann. I highly recommend you read it.